CORE FALSE BELIEF #21 · AFTER PAINFUL EXPERIENCES

"It was my fault."

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Where it often comes from

After abuse, an assault, an accident, a parent's divorce, or a loved one's death, many people blame themselves. Children especially assume they caused what happened, because it is less frightening than believing the adults around them were unsafe. Abusers often tell victims it was their fault. Self-blame can also feel like control: if it was my fault, maybe I can prevent it next time.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture is clear that each person is responsible for his own wrongdoing; the guilt of one is not placed on another. If someone harmed you, the responsibility belongs to the person who did it. God is near to the brokenhearted, and Jesus came to bind up the brokenhearted and set captives free. Where we have truly done wrong, God forgives completely. But where we were wronged, He does not ask us to carry the blame. In Christ, there is no condemnation.

> *"The soul who sins is the one who will die. A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son. The righteousness of the righteous man will fall upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked man will fall upon him"* (Ezekiel 18:20).

Also see

> "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit" (Psalm 34:18).

> "The Spirit of the Lord GOD is on Me, because the LORD has anointed Me to preach good news to the poor. He has sent Me to bind up the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives and freedom to the prisoners" (Isaiah 61:1).

> "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus" (Romans 8:1).

> "As for you, what you intended against me for evil, God intended for good, in order to accomplish a day like this—to preserve the lives of many people" (Genesis 50:20).

Common self-statements

- I should have stopped it.
- If I had been better, it wouldn't have happened.
- I must have done something to cause it.
- I deserved what happened.
- I should have seen it coming.
- It's my fault they left.

Common logical errors

- Personalization: Taking responsibility for something another person chose to do.
- Hindsight bias: Judging my past self by what I know now.
- Emotional reasoning: Believing I'm to blame because I feel guilty.
- Should statements: Insisting I should have been able to prevent it.

Challenging questions

- Who actually made the choices that caused harm?
- What did I know, and what power did I have, at the time?
- Would I blame a child or friend in the same situation?
- Did someone tell me it was my fault, and why might they have said that?
- Is there anything I truly need to confess, and anything I need to set down?
- What does God say about the brokenhearted and about blame?

Truth summary

> Something painful happened, and I have carried the blame for it. But responsibility belongs to the person who caused the harm, not to me. I did what I could with what I knew then. God is near to me in my pain, and He does not ask me to carry guilt that isn't mine.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Guilt/Shame
- Child Abuse/Neglect
- Mercy
- Forgiveness
- Help

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Suffering
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Dear Younger Me — MercyMe
Past wounds and choices do not have to become a person's permanent identity.

Clean — Natalie Grant
God's cleansing grace challenges the belief that shame or sin makes a person beyond restoration.

Chain Breaker — Zach Williams
Christ offers rescue and freedom to people who feel trapped by their past.

Softly and Tenderly — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
This older hymn pictures Christ's gracious invitation to return rather than hide in shame.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "It was my fault"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"It was my fault." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who made the choices that caused harm?
- ☐ What did I know and what power did I have then?
- ☐ Would I blame a child or friend?
- ☐ Who told me it was my fault?
- ☐ Is there anything to confess, and anything to set down?
- ☐ What does God say about blame and the brokenhearted?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ The guilt of another is not mine to carry.
- ☐ God is near to the brokenhearted.
- ☐ I did what I could with what I knew.
- ☐ Feeling guilty does not make me guilty.
- ☐ Jesus came to heal the brokenhearted.
- ☐ In Christ there is no condemnation.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Ezekiel 18:20
  "The soul who sins is the one who will die. A son will not bear the iniquity of his father, and a father will not bear the iniquity of his son. The righteousness of the righteous man will fall upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked man will fall upon him."
- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."
- ☐ Isaiah 61:1
  "The Spirit of the Lord GOD is on Me, because the LORD has anointed Me to preach good news to the poor. He has sent Me to bind up the brokenhearted, to proclaim liberty to the captives and freedom to the prisoners."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Blame I set down: Each day, write one self-blaming thought and answer it with a truth from this card.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 34:18 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The Lord is near to me when my heart is broken. I don't have to carry blame that isn't mine.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Guilt/Shame" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Draw the responsibility pie. Draw a circle and divide it among everyone and everything that contributed to what happened. Notice how small, or empty, your slice really is.
- [ ] Write to your younger self. Write a short letter to yourself at the age it happened, telling that person what you know now.
- [ ] Tell a safe person. Share your story, or part of it, with a counselor, pastor, or trusted friend who will listen without blame.
- [ ] Get specialized help. If what happened was abuse or assault, a counselor trained in trauma can help you heal at a safe pace.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "It was my fault": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A time I set down blame
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~It was my fault.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have blamed myself for what happened for so long. Thank You that You are near to the brokenhearted. Help me lay down guilt that is not mine, confess what is, and receive Your healing and peace. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

CORE FALSE BELIEF #22 · AFTER PAINFUL EXPERIENCES

“What happened makes me dirty or bad.”

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Where it often comes from

This belief often follows sexual abuse, assault, betrayal, or humiliation. Shame can attach itself to the person who was hurt rather than to the person who did the harm. Abusers sometimes tell victims they are dirty or that no one will want them. Religious messages about purity, when misapplied, can deepen the feeling of being stained or ruined.

What Scripture teaches

In the Gospels, Jesus touched people others considered unclean and said, “Be clean!” He was not made dirty by them; they were made clean by Him. Those who look to the Lord are radiant, and their faces are never covered with shame. God gives a crown of beauty instead of ashes. In Christ, anyone is a new creation, and believers can draw near to God with hearts sprinkled clean. What was done to you does not make you dirty, and nothing you have done is beyond His cleansing.

> *“Those who look to Him are radiant with joy; their faces shall never be ashamed”* (Psalm 34:5).

Also see

> “Moved with compassion, Jesus reached out His hand and touched the man. ‘I am willing,’ He said. ‘Be clean!’” (Mark 1:41).

> “To console the mourners in Zion— to give them a crown of beauty for ashes, the oil of joy for mourning, and a garment of praise for a spirit of despair. So they will be called oaks of righteousness, the planting of the LORD, that He may be glorified” (Isaiah 61:3).

> “Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!” (2 Corinthians 5:17).

> “Let us draw near with a sincere heart in full assurance of faith, having our hearts sprinkled to cleanse us from a guilty conscience and our bodies washed with pure water” (Hebrews 10:22).

Common self-statements

- I’m ruined.
- No one would want me if they knew.
- I feel dirty no matter what I do.
- I’m damaged goods.
- God must see me as stained.
- What happened is who I am now.

Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Believing I am dirty because I feel dirty.
- Labeling: Calling myself ruined or damaged because of what happened.
- Personalization: Taking on shame that belongs to the person who harmed me.
- Overgeneralization: Letting one experience define my whole identity.

Challenging questions

- Whose shame am I carrying: mine or the person who hurt me?
- Who told me I was dirty or ruined?
- How did Jesus treat people others called unclean?
- Would I see a friend as dirty if this had happened to her or him?
- What does God say about those who look to Him?
- What would it mean to see myself as God sees me?

Truth summary

> Something painful and wrong happened. The shame belongs to the one who did it, not to me. Jesus is not repelled by me; He reaches out and makes me clean. I am not ruined. In Christ I am a new creation, and my face does not have to be covered with shame.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Guilt/Shame
- Child Abuse/Neglect
- Born Again
- Grace
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Suffering

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Clean — Natalie Grant
God's cleansing grace challenges the belief that shame or sin makes a person beyond restoration.

Hello My Name Is — Matthew West
God's redeemed-child identity challenges labels of regret and defeat.

Amazing Grace My Chains Are Gone — Chris Tomlin
Salvation and freedom come through grace rather than earning acceptance.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "What happened makes me dirty or bad"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"What happened makes me dirty or bad." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Whose shame am I carrying?
- ☐ Who told me I was dirty?
- ☐ How did Jesus treat people called unclean?
- ☐ Would I see a friend as dirty?
- ☐ What does God say about those who look to Him?
- ☐ What would it mean to see myself as God does?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ What was done to me does not make me dirty.
- ☐ Jesus touches me and says, "Be clean!"
- ☐ Those who look to Him are radiant.
- ☐ I am a new creation in Christ.
- ☐ God gives beauty for ashes.
- ☐ The shame belongs to the one who harmed me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 34:5
  "Those who look to Him are radiant with joy; their faces shall never be ashamed."
- ☐ Mark 1:41
  "Moved with compassion, Jesus reached out His hand and touched the man. 'I am willing,' He said. 'Be clean!'"
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 5:17
  "Therefore if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away. Behold, the new has come!"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Shame and truth: Each day, write one moment when shame came up, and one truth from this card that answers it.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 34:5 becomes: "Linda can write: "When I look to the Lord, my face does not have to be covered with shame.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
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Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Return the shame. Write what happened and, next to it, write who is responsible. Then write, "This shame belongs to them, not to me."
- [ ] Read Mark 1:40–42. Read how Jesus touched the man with leprosy. Write what it shows you about how Jesus sees you.
- [ ] Care for your body. Do one kind thing for your body this week, such as a warm bath, rest, or a walk, treating it as something God made good.
- [ ] Get trauma-informed help. Healing from abuse or assault is hard to do alone. A counselor trained in trauma can walk with you at a safe pace.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "What happened makes me dirty or bad": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A moment I saw myself as clean
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Tue				
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Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
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My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
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Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~What happened makes me dirty or bad.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord Jesus, I have felt dirty and ruined because of what happened. Thank You that You reached out and touched those others called unclean. Lift my shame, heal my wounds, and help me see myself as You see me: clean, loved, and new. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.